



THE
LAY COUNSELOR
ACADEMY

Advice: Why (& How) We Avoid It



What is Advice?

Advice, simply, is telling someone what to do. This includes telling clients what they 'should do', 'have to' do, or 'must do' as well as more subtle forms of advice-giving, such as suggestions, and 'have you thought of...' and 'don't you think you should...' questions. Sometimes advice can come in the form of sharing our own experience, if we share it because we believe someone should do what we did.

Why we avoid it:

- 1. It doesn't work well:** Research shows that advice is inferior to other forms of help in counseling.
- 2. It diminishes listening quality:** When we give advice, we are telling our clients we are done listening.
- 3. It creates resistance:** Humans have a need for psychological autonomy; advice often threatens this, then clients 'push back'.
- 4. It undermines the therapeutic alliance:** Giving advice does not communicate empathy for most clients; it hinders trust and collaboration.
- 5. It stunts growth:** Giving advice prevents clients from developing their own decision-making skills, enhancing their self-knowledge, and listening to their inner wisdom.



6. **It indicates that we are experts on clients' lives** (more so than they are!), which creates a power differential.

7. **It ignores the client's unique personality, goals, culture, values, and beliefs;** advice cannot account for all these infinitely varied factors.

8. **It shifts accountability:** Once we tell someone what to do, we bear some responsibility for what happens if clients follow our advice. This is worrisome for clients as well as for us.

9. **It is the opposite of Know-nothing Mind** from 'Ways of Being'. When we give advice, we have an agenda for our client.

10. **It falsely assumes similarity:** Even if we have similar lived experiences of our client, it does not mean what we've done to help ourselves is the right path for our client.

How Do We Break the Advice Habit?

For many of us, it may be quite difficult not to give advice! We may have grown up with people who primarily interacted with us by telling us what to do, which might make us more likely to do the same to others. We might believe our job is to advise others, or that this is what clients want from us. Once we begin trying to stop, we might realize just how much of our interactions with clients (and sometimes people in our personal lives) are characterized by us telling or suggesting to others what they should do!



Advice-Avoidance Practices:

1. **Notice when we feel the urge to give advice:** This is the most important. Normally, when we feel an urge to give advice, it's because we are having feelings about what the client is sharing.
2. **Internally manage feelings and resist the urge:** Remind ourselves that the solution will not come from us.
3. **Re-focus on the client:** Shift back to listening to our client; ask them an open-ended question about their perspective, their thoughts about solutions.

Frequently Asked Questions about Advice:

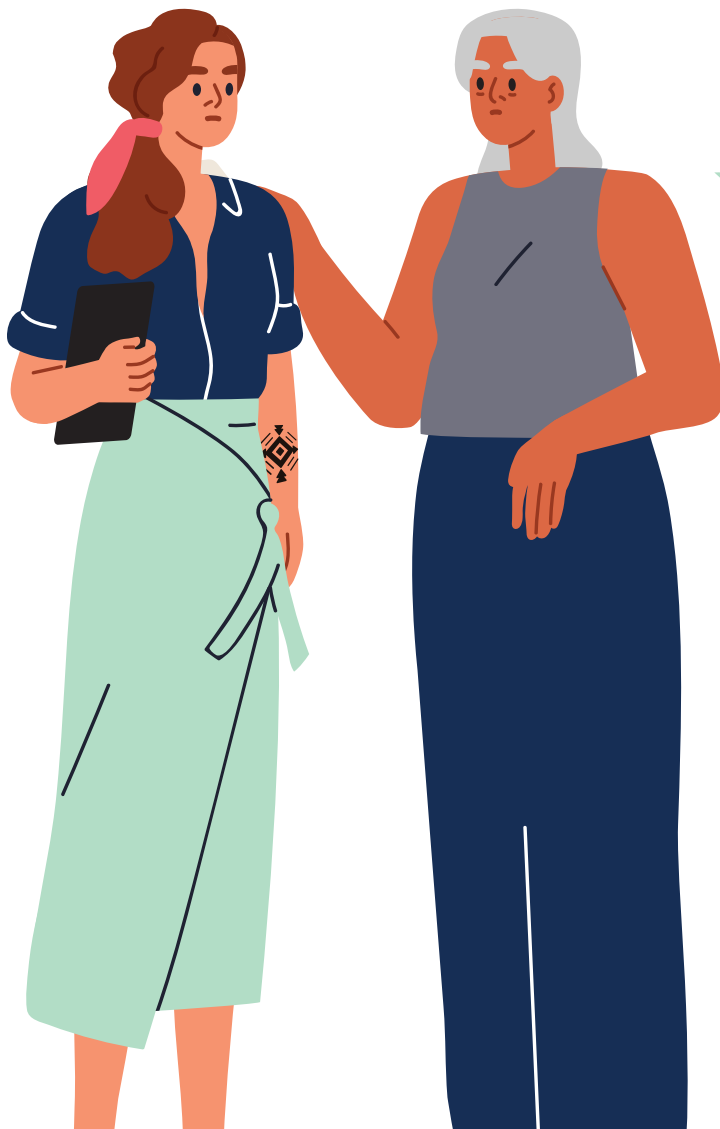
1. *What if we have information we are sure would be helpful to our client?*

Giving information is very different from giving advice. Giving information is objective; it is agenda-less; it is just information for clients as they make their own decisions. (See the AATA article for a way to give information that helps us steer clear of advice)

2. *What if a client asks you for advice?*

When a client asks us what they should do, we can wonder to ourselves—*what is making them ask us? What is keeping them from knowing what is right for themselves? What would be different for them if they could answer their own question?* We remind ourselves that a client asking for our advice can be an indication that they don't trust themselves or that they have trouble listening to themselves.

We pause, reflect, and ask them what they think:



"It sounds like you want to know what I think you should do... Can I ask you... What does your wisest self tell you about this?"

OR

"I hear you, you want my opinion... I feel sure you would know better than I would, what the right thing to do is for you... What do you think that is?"

OR

"You want me to tell you what I think... I'm wondering how you normally make decisions, how you 'know' what the best thing to do is..."

3. *Are there any circumstances when advice is warranted?*

Direct advice can sometimes be helpful when people are in crisis because their prefrontal cortex (executive function) is not working optimally, making it difficult to answer questions. If someone is having a panic attack, escalating in anger, in a crisis situation, or otherwise experiencing very strong emotions, giving clear directives can be useful when we use 'I' pronouns. For example, when someone is having a panic attack: 'let's go outside' or when we are on the phone with someone driving, who is very upset, 'I need you to pull over'.

